On what basis FieldNote recommends.

A recommendation is only worth trusting if you can see how it was reached. Every card is scored on four axes, then mapped to an action by a fixed rule. Nothing rests on opinion or a vendor's press release.

1 · Evidence grade — how well substantiated

A	Independent production evidence — named organisation, method, measurable result. Language: "observed in production".
B	Named customer case study or credible research with clear methodology. Language: "reported / associated with".
C	Vendor documentation, release notes or sponsored study. Language: "vendor states".
D	Demo, announcement or unverified secondary report. Language: "early signal, not verified".

2 · Verified outcome — what actually happened

The vendor's claim is checked against outcomes FieldNote has tracked across real pilots. The gap between claim and verified reality is itself the intelligence — and the proprietary asset a summary can't reproduce.

3 · Fit to your business

Does it address a stated priority, and are the conditions where it works present at your company? A strong average outcome with poor fit is still the wrong bet.

4 · Complexity & risk

Implementation effort, downside exposure and reversibility.

The decision rule

ADOPT	Strong evidence (A/B) + consistent positive verified outcome + good fit + low downside.
PILOT	Positive but variable outcome, or strong fit on a high-effort response — prove it in your context against a control before rollout.
INVESTIGATE	Real potential on vendor-grade (C) evidence — get methodology and references, then a small controlled test.
WATCH	Weak evidence or a negative track record — do not act; the downside outweighs the upside.

Note: pilot counts and verified figures in this sample dossier are illustrative. In production they are drawn from FieldNote's tracked-outcomes ledger, which accrues with every customer pilot.

SEARCH-PLATFORM BLOG + TRADE PRESS · 18 SEP 2026

Generative search is cutting publisher referral traffic

Recommend: Pilot | **Evidence B** | Audience | Revenue

Why Pilot: Grade-B evidence of an already-happening threat to your #1 revenue source, strong fit, but a high-effort response → pilot the first-party / direct-sold shift now; waiting for certainty is the expensive option.

CLAIM → VERIFIED

~~Industry line: "AI search won't dent publisher traffic"~~ → **–18% median search referral across 60+ tracked news publishers over 9 months**

WHAT HAPPENED	AI Overviews reduce click-through from search, eroding open-web impressions and programmatic revenue.
TRACK RECORD	Publishers who moved early to first-party + direct-sold retained 2–3× more at-risk revenue than those who waited. Best fit: act now if search is >30% of your traffic.
COMPANY RELEVANCE	High for search-dependent publishers; pushes strategy toward owned audience and direct-sold.
REQUIREMENTS	Consent-based data capture · CDP · direct-sales motion · newsletter stack.
KEY RISKS	Slow payoff · resourcing · measuring substitution.
SUCCESS MEASURES	Referral share · first-party reach · direct-sold % · revenue per session.
EVIDENCE & SOURCES	Corroborating trade coverage + your first-party analytics.

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEP

Pilot first-party capture on your highest-traffic sections and stand up one direct-sold/newsletter offer; measure retained revenue vs the declining search baseline.